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Ed Martin loses bulk of his DOJ mandate

He will no longer head task force that pushed for probes of Trump’s foes

BY PERRY STEIN
AND BETH REINHARD

Top Justice Department officials have stripped Ed Martin of the bulk of his expansive responsibilities, leaving the staunch ally of President Donald Trump on the sidelines of many of the controversial investigations he has championed, according to two people familiar with the personnel move.

As a result of the changes, Martin will no longer chair the department’s Weaponization Working Group, which was tasked with reviewing special counsel Jack Smith’s prosecutions of Trump and other examples of what Trump sees as “prosecutorial abuse,” according to the people, who spoke on the condition of anonymity to discuss a personnel move that has not been made public. The group itself continues to meet. Martin also lost his title as an assistant attorney general.

Martin will continue to serve as the Justice Department’s pardon attorney but will no longer work at department headquarters. Instead, his office will be located in another Justice Department building in Northeast Washington, pulling him away from the attorney general and the most powerful figures in the department, according to a person familiar with the move. The pardon office is in that Northeast Washington building.

Justice Department officials informed Martin in early December of the demotion, and it went into effect at the end of 2025. It is unclear whether he will remain

SEE MARTIN ON A4



DREA CORNEJO/FOR THE WASHINGTON POST

Cutting off a lifeline

Fla. is set to restrict eligibility for free HIV medication, putting it out of reach for many

BY DAVID OVALLE

Medications have kept Tori Samuel’s HIV at bay for decades. The part-time worker from Ocala, Florida, has thrived, marrying her husband and giving birth to three children, none of whom have the virus.

But now she risks losing access as Florida prepares to drastically restrict eligibility for free medication, putting treatment potentially out of reach for thousands of residents. A caseworker told Samuel, 43, that her family’s household income of just over \$3,800

a month is too much to receive assistance for pills that can cost more than \$5,000 a month.

Her medications are provided by the Florida AIDS Drug Assistance Program, funded through a federal initiative that has long served as a lifeline for hundreds of thousands of Americans living with HIV who otherwise could not afford expensive anti-retroviral drugs and care. State officials, citing financial difficulties, are lowering the income threshold to receive benefits and are no longer covering certain medications.

Samuel, whose job processing packages doesn’t offer health insurance, does not know how she’ll pay for her medication when the restrictions take effect March 1.

“It’s terrifying — and it’s not just me,” she said. “There’s so many other people who are affected.”

The National Alliance of State and Territorial AIDS Directors (NASTAD) estimates that 16,000 Floridians will lose assistance for either the drugs or premiums for health plans that cover them. The Jan. 8 announcement

SEE HIV ON A6

Tori Samuel embraces her 12-year-old daughter, Heaven, outside her home on Jan. 26 in Ocala, Florida. “If I don’t have access to my medicine, I can’t be the mother I need to be,” Samuel said. “My kids need me.”

Gaza-Egypt crossing reopens after nearly 2 years

BY ABBIE CHEESEMAN,
SIHAM SHAMALAKH,
HEBA FAROUK MAHFOUZ
AND LIOR SOROKA

The Rafah border crossing between Egypt and Gaza reopened Monday for the first time in nearly two years, allowing a small number of Palestinians to both enter and exit the territory as part of a U.S.-backed ceasefire to end Israel’s war with Hamas.

It was not immediately clear how many Palestinians crossed the border Monday, but the opening appeared largely symbolic: Only about a dozen people traveled each way, according to a European official with knowledge of the situation who spoke on the condition of anonymity because of the sensitive nature of the crossing.

The European Union has deployed an observer force to monitor the crossing, along with Palestinian, Egyptian and Israeli authorities.

“It was a very difficult day,” the official said. “It was not an easy first day of operation.”

The Israeli military seized the border in May 2024 as it swept through Rafah in southern Gaza,

SEE RAFAH ON A16



BARRY REEGER/AP

Groundhog sees his shadow

Emerging from his wintertime burrow, Punxsutawney Phil on Monday forecast six more weeks of winter, his handlers said. The rodent’s prediction follows a snowy January. **Story, A5**

Banfield convicted of killing wife in plot with au pair

BY EMMA UBER

Brendan Banfield, the Virginia man accused of plotting with his family’s au pair to impersonate his wife on a sexual fetish website to frame a stranger as her killer, was found guilty Monday of aggravated murder in the 2023 killings of Christine Banfield and Joseph Ryan.

A jury in Fairfax County deliberated for nearly nine hours before finding Banfield, 40, guilty of both murders as well as two lesser charges. His sentencing is scheduled for May 8. The aggravated murder charges carry a mandatory life sentence without parole.

The conviction came in the trial’s fourth week, after prosecutors painted Banfield as a man so deeply in love with the young Brazilian au pair that he orchestrated an elaborate plot to shoot

Ryan, whom he had lured to the family’s Northern Virginia home under the pretense of a rough sex fantasy, then kill his wife with the stranger’s knife.

Prosecutors had testimony from Banfield’s former mistress, au pair Juliana Peres Magalhães, to corroborate their theory. Banfield told jurors that he had interrupted a violent attack on his wife but shot her attacker too late to save her. The trial revolved around circumstantial forensic evidence and the competing accounts from the only surviving witnesses to the killings. In the end, jurors weren’t convinced by Banfield’s story.

Magalhães was initially charged with Ryan’s murder but pleaded guilty to involuntary manslaughter in a deal that set the stage for her testimony. **See BANFIELD ON A9**

Change is coming quickly to Venezuela, but relief still feels far away for some

BY ANA VANESSA HERRERO
AND SAMANTHA SCHMIDT

CARACAS, VENEZUELA — American oil traders are poised to descend on Venezuela’s capital — and may soon be able to fly here direct. The Trump administration is preparing to reopen the U.S. Embassy. The socialist govern-

ment here has made the nationalized oil industry friendlier for foreign investors, and the U.S. Treasury has eased sanctions to allow U.S. companies to buy and sell Venezuelan oil.

The dizzying changes here would have seemed unthinkable just a month ago, when U.S. forces were surrounding the country,

seizing Venezuelan oil and menacing the authoritarian government.

But the U.S. capture Jan. 3 of President Nicolás Maduro, and President Donald Trump’s vow to exploit the world’s largest proven oil reserves, has fundamentally transformed relations between the two countries. The administration is working with Delcy

Rodríguez, Maduro’s vice president, rather than María Corina Machado, the popular opposition leader whom Trump previously championed.

The economic outlook for Venezuela has improved dramatically; after years of economic collapse, rising unemployment and soaring inflation, some economists say it’s

not far-fetched to imagine double-digit growth this year.

In the latest surprise move, Rodríguez on Friday proposed a general amnesty for hundreds of political prisoners, some of whom have been held for decades — and promised to repurpose the infamous Helicoide prison, an alleged

SEE VENEZUELA ON A16

IN THE NEWS

Trade agreement The United States and India have sealed a deal on tariffs after months of tensions, helping stabilize a relationship that had been in decline. **A13**

An Olympian’s journey For U.S. snowboarder Maddy Schaffrick, the Milan Cortina Games are a promise kept to her younger self. **B7**

THE NATION
Takeaways from the latest campaign finance reports. **A3**
Tenants living near an Immigration and Customs Enforcement facility in Oregon sued over the use of tear gas. **A4**

THE WORLD
Cuts to global aid could lead to 9.4 million extra deaths by 2030, a study projects. **A13**
Peter Mandelson resigned from Britain’s Labour Party over his ties to Jeffrey Epstein. **A13**

The U.S. and Iran are expected to discuss a nuclear deal Friday in Istanbul. **A14**

THE ECONOMY
The U.S. dollar, under pressure on multiple fronts, has lost more than a tenth of its value since President Donald Trump retook office. **A20**

STYLE
With trophies in hand, Bad Bunny, Billie Eilish and SZA railed against ICE at the Grammys. **B1**

SPORTS
“Cashing all day”: Feds say at the heart of an online gambler’s hustle is one of the biggest point-shaving networks in American history. **B7**

THE REGION
Widespread heating problems have been reported at District schools amid a brutal cold spell. **B13**
The remaining statues honoring Confederate figures at the Virginia Capitol would be removed under a Democratic bill. **B13**

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The Washington Post
Year 149, No. 54481

